

Why models love Dominik Szoboszlai (and should you too?)

Is he truly an essential pick?



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Dominik Szoboszlai's (£7.0m) FPL ownership is approaching 50%, and I bet that if you read this, you at least considered him. More likely, he was in some of the drafts you saved in the app.

Popular data models that integrate historical performance data, market odds, and even contextual modelling, such as tactical changes, have him ranked among the very best picks.

This is Solio's top 10 for the eight-gameweek horizon...

Name	Price	1	2	3	4	5	6	7	8	Average	▼
Haaland 	15.5	7.03	6.26	7.98	5.42	7.06	5.41	8.09	5.79	6.63	
B.Fernandes 	12.0	6.42	7.38	5.57	5.23	5.79	6.09	5.57	6.38	6.05	
Gabriel 	8.0	6.23	4.51	4.43	5.38	4.61	5.44	4.80	5.47	5.11	
Szoboszlai 	7.0	4.78	5.26	5.39	5.34	4.76	4.43	4.73	5.17	4.98	
Palmer 	9.5	5.08	5.15	3.47	6.26	4.60	5.20	4.60	5.00	4.92	
Saka 	9.5	3.72	3.98	5.11	5.14	4.83	5.59	4.99	5.51	4.86	
Semenyo 	8.5	5.01	4.65	5.66	4.00	5.16	3.99	5.74	4.29	4.81	
Gibbs-White 	8.0	5.27	3.94	4.86	4.26	5.89	4.58	3.85	5.19	4.73	
João Pedro 	7.5	4.68	4.97	3.39	5.92	4.47	5.12	4.38	4.89	4.73	
Isak 	9.0	4.59	5.05	5.22	5.25	4.59	4.35	4.33	4.24	4.70	

... and here's Copilot's:

PLAYER ↕	GW1 ↕	GW2 ↕	GW3 ↕	GW4 ↕	GW5 ↕	GW6 ↕	GW7 ↕	GW8 ↕	XPT
Haaland >	7.4 88' 📉	7.2 88' 📉	8.1 88' 📉	6.6 86' 📈	7.8 88' 📈	6.3 88' 📉	8.0 88' 📉	6.8 88' 📉	58
B.Fernandes >	6.6 89' 📉	6.3 89' 📉	5.5 89' 📉	5.2 89' 📈	5.4 89' 📉	6.0 89' 📉	5.5 89' 📉	6.3 89' 📉	46
Gabriel >	6.4 89' 📉	5.1 89' 📉	5.3 89' 📉	5.8 89' 📉	5.1 89' 📉	5.8 89' 📉	5.5 89' 📉	5.9 89' 📉	44
Semenyo >	5.0 88' 📉	5.0 88' 📉	5.2 88' 📉	4.4 88' 📉	5.3 88' 📉	4.1 88' 📉	5.2 88' 📉	4.7 88' 📉	38
Anderson >	4.9 89' 📉	4.9 89' 📉	5.1 89' 📉	4.5 89' 📉	5.0 89' 📉	4.4 89' 📉	5.1 89' 📉	4.7 89' 📉	38
Mbeumo >	5.2 86' 📉	5.2 86' 📉	4.6 86' 📉	4.4 86' 📉	4.5 86' 📉	5.1 86' 📉	4.6 86' 📉	5.1 86' 📉	38
Saka >	5.3 80' 📉	4.2 80' 📉	4.8 80' 📉	4.8 80' 📉	4.6 80' 📉	5.0 80' 📉	4.7 80' 📉	5.2 80' 📉	38
Szoboszlai >	4.5 89' 📉	5.0 89' 📉	5.0 89' 📉	5.0 89' 📉	4.6 89' 📉	4.2 89' 📉	4.6 89' 📉	5.0 89' 📉	37
O'Reilly >	4.5 88' 📉	4.7 88' 📉	5.6 88' 📉	3.7 88' 📉	5.5 88' 📉	3.5 88' 📉	5.5 88' 📉	4.3 88' 📉	37
Thiago >	4.8 89' 📉	4.7 89' 📉	5.0 89' 📉	4.5 89' 📉	4.7 89' 📉	4.2 89' 📉	4.4 89' 📉	4.7 89' 📉	37

You have surely heard the phrases “he has multiple routes to points” or “you can hold him through the fixture swing, and he’ll just tick along”.

Today, we’ll look at whether these hold up to a quick breakdown and whether we could possibly gain an edge by betting against him.

He played everywhere

The issue with analysing Szoboszlai’s expected points at the start of the season is that predictive models rely on last season’s data (and earlier) and likely place significant weight on it.

Those data are heavily skewed by the fact that he didn’t fulfil one role but moved around the pitch regularly:

- **AMC:** 1,500 minutes
- **Right fullback:** 800
- **Number #6/#8:** 700
- **Right winger:** 600

And that's only based on his starting position. He often switched them during the game. We'll use this when working out his realistic output in the rest of the article.

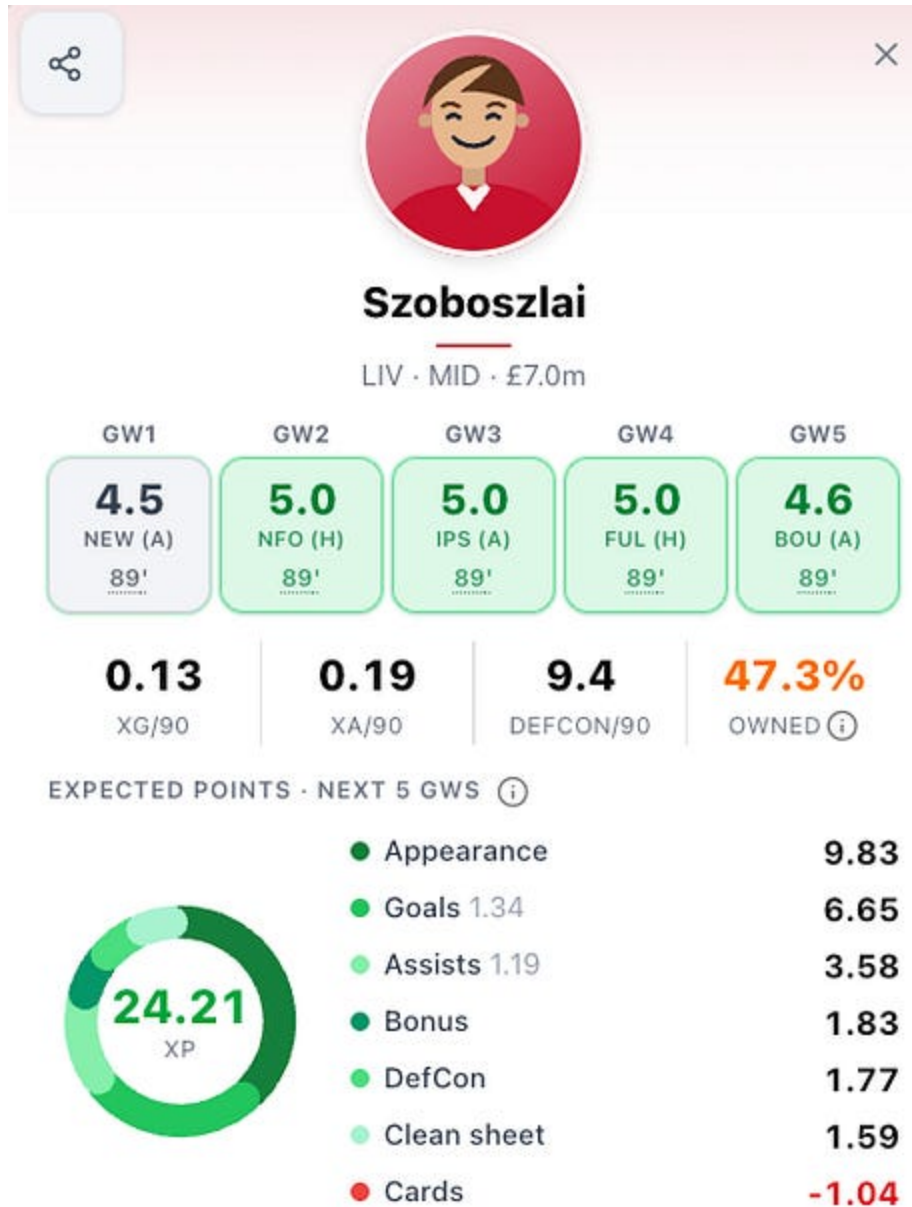
Andoni Iraola stated that he sees **Florian Wirtz** as the best fit for a number 10 role, so we can reasonably expect Szoboszlai to play deeper in the upcoming campaign.

The Hungarian's profile also seems to suit a double pivot role under the new coach perfectly – he's relentless in pressing, fast, a great tackler, and capable of playing throughballs from deeper areas.

 **Tell your mates in the pub:** Szoboszlai's vertical passes from half-spaces create an 80% greater threat than an average midfielder, according to advanced non-shot models.

However, it's not completely out of the question that he starts the season at right back, given Liverpool are short on personnel for that position (Bradley is expected to return in October/November and Gomez is also injured).

Let's see what happens in the transfer market.



Appearance

The xPoints breakdown like this [Copilot's](#) makes you realise how crucial it is to have a 90-minute player.

Appearance points are one thing, but spending the whole game on the pitch is obviously great news for everything else – it allows you to hit the DEFCON threshold, score bonus points, and contribute with some final product.

It might seem obvious to you, but not to everyone.

DEFCONs

Last season, Szoboszlai averaged 9.44 defensive contributions per 90 minutes and reached the threshold in 28% of matches.

In total, he recorded **20 DC points**, equivalent to 4 goals.

Some maths, huh?

You'd expect a discrepancy between the defensive contributions he produced across all the roles he played and the DEFCON two-pointers he earned.

To simplify, I merged those roles into two categories to see how many defensive duels he racked up:

- **Defensive roles:** 10.80 def. contributions per 90, with a 42% completion rate
- **Offensive roles:** 8.82, and 22%

Those offensive numbers are a bit skewed because there were quite a few games where he started advanced but moved deeper as the game progressed.

This breakdown from [Chewie](#) shows that nicely:



ChewieFPL
@chewiefpl



Dominik Szoboszlai (7.0m) defcon breakdown #FPL

I've highlighted the games where he played **only** in midfield in green and the games where he played **at least half** in midfield in yellow

If you have any questions feel free to ask

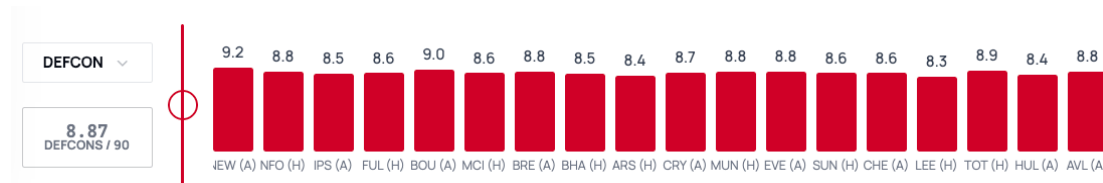
Szoboszlai	Minutes	Position	# of defcons	xGI	YC/RCs	Other returns	FPL points
Gameweek							
GW1	90	DM	11	0.19			2
GW2	90	RB (80 mins) AM (10 mins)	9	0.01			2
GW3	90	RB	14	0.05		1 goal, 3 bonus	13
GW4	90	RB (45 mins) DM (45 mins)	9	0.28			3
GW5	90	AM	10	0.1	YC		1
GW6	90	AM (45 mins) RB (20 mins) DM (15 mins)	16	0.45		1 bonus	5
GW7	90	AM (45 mins) RB (45 mins)	10	0.59	YC		1
GW8	90	AM (62 mins) RB (28 mins)	12	0.11			4
GW9	90	AM (62 mins) RB (28 mins)	22	0.26		1 assist, 3 bonus	10
GW10	90	AM	7	0.38	YC		2
GW11	90	AM	9	0.05	YC		1
GW12	90	RB	9	0.49			2
GW13	90	RW	7	0.07			3
GW14	90	RW (45 mins) AM (45 mins)	5	0.39			2
GW15	90	RW	8	0.79		1 goal, 1 bonus	8
GW16	83	RW (26 mins) RB (57 mins)	5	0.17			3
GW17	90	RW (76 mins) RB (14 mins)	8	0.25	YC		
GW18							
GW19	90	AM	6	0.19			3
GW20	90	RW (76 mins) AM (14 mins)	4	0.16			2
GW21	90	AM	3	0.23			3
GW22	90	AM (87 mins) CM (3 mins)	4	1.32		(missed pen)	0
GW23	90	AM (59 mins) RB (31 mins)	7	0.31		1 goal, 1 assist, 3 bonus	13
GW24	90	RB	13	0.24		1 bonus	5
GW25	90	RB	15	0.27	RC	1 goal, 2 bonus	8
GW26							
GW27	90	RCM/RB	8	0.35			3
GW28	90	AM	8	0.32	YC	1 assist	4
GW29	90	AM	15	0.25		1 bonus	5
GW30	90	RB	14	0.5		1 goal, 2 bonus	11
GW31	90	RW	18	0.28	YC		3
GW32	90	DM (68 mins) AM (22 mins)	15	0.07			5
GW33	90	DM (83 mins) RCM (7 mins)	6	0.29		1 assist	5
GW34	90	DM (79 mins) RCM (11 mins)	7	0.25	YC		1
GW35	90	AM	10	0.4		1 goal, 1 assist, 3 bonus	13
GW36	90	AM	3	0.33			2
GW37	90	AM (66 mins) DM (24 mins)	3	0.48		2 assists, 1 bonus	9
GW38	90	AM	9	0.77			2
defcon/90:	9.44						
hit rate:	10/36 = 27.8%						
xGI/90:	0.324						
points/game:	4.42						

When you account for this and look only at games without those split roles (solely AM during the game), it was 8.10 defensive contributions and just a 9% completion rate. There were many games in which he recorded around 10 actions, narrowly missing the 12 CBTR midfield threshold.

You can expect more intensity with Iraola at the helm – when it comes to loose-ball duels, Bournemouth ranked **2nd in their own third, 1st in the middle of the pitch, and 3rd in the final third**, which should bode well for ball recoveries.

Generally, I don't think he'll be short on defensive work, duelling and running (both ways).

Solio has his defcons/p90 set to 8.87, which feels like the reasonable default setting.



Assists

The important part of his creativity and ability **to produce passes directly leading to a shot** is set pieces.

Last season, he took over 45% of Liverpool's corners, and 55% of his key passes came from dead-ball situations. As for xG assisted, he created 4.70 from open play and 3.20 from set pieces, which is understandable given the nature of those chances.

This means that if he keeps his duties, which is widely expected, his assist potential will remain extremely high, because his technical qualities are good enough to generate chances in volume. Not only are his open-play crosses great from both deep and wide areas, but he can also play those great throughballs from both half-spaces I mentioned earlier.

When playing as a number ten, his xA numbers were elite, and they were still well above average in all other positions, including when playing in

the double pivot.

There's a slight question about whether he will keep taking the same volume of right-sided corners, but at the same time, **Mohamed Salah** leaving the team means someone will inherit 55 corners he took.

So this is perhaps something to look into in the upcoming friendlies. Every game from here gets more important than the last for tracking those trends.



Bonus

There's always a strong chance he will sneak in bonus points from time to time, as he will remain heavily involved throughout the game.

He was ranked 16th among midfielders for baseline BPS last season.

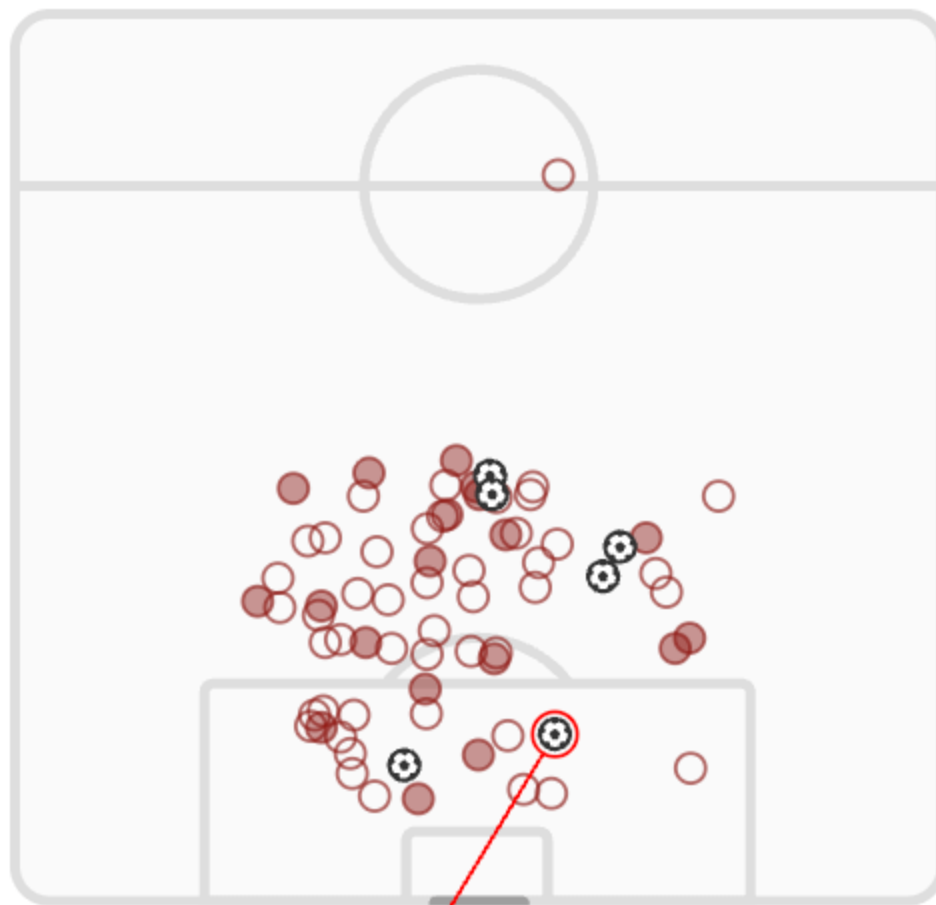
As expected, it was driven mainly by his passing – a high volume of key passes and crosses, with solid pass accuracy (yes, it's 2026 and passing percentage is still a thing in FPL). A large part of it is also his defensive activity.

Nothing you should base your analysis on, but it's there.

Goals

The open-play goal threat wasn't really there.

Of his 69 shots, 18 were from inside the box, just 26%. When he played as an attacking midfielder, he averaged 1.20 shots and 0.11 expected goals per 90 minutes. When part of a double pivot, he averaged 2 shots and 0.07 xG p90.



71
Shots

6
Goals

4.81
xG

Last season's shot map (source: fotmob.com)

Four of his six goals came from free kicks – he converted 29% of his attempts, which is unsustainable even for elite players in this area.

Across his previous five seasons at Liverpool and Leipzig, his conversion rate is 14.6%, which is a more realistic rate (and still amazing!).

Anyway, he's a pretty good finisher, with 4 goals above his expected in a substantial sample of over 13,000 minutes and almost 300 shots.

Although penalties are difficult to predict, Bournemouth were getting quite a few of them under Iraola, and **Alexander Isak's** minutes might be managed, so Szoboszlai being right behind in the pecking order is a nice bonus.

SEASON	TEAM	COMPETITION	Ø	👕	⚽	⚡	🟡	🔴
2025/2026	 Liverpool	 Premier League	7.3	36	6	7	8	1
2024/2025	 Liverpool	 Premier League	7.1	36	6	6	6	0
2023/2024	 Liverpool	 Premier League	7.3	33	3	2	1	0
2022/2023	 RB Leipzig	 Bundesliga	7.3	31	6	8	5	2
2021/2022	 RB Leipzig	 Bundesliga	7.2	31	6	8	2	0

Clean sheet

This is difficult to assess at this stage of the season, with more than three weeks to go before the summer transfer window closes.

The good news is that Liverpool's fixture run of **Newcastle, Nottingham Forest, Ipswich, Fulham** and **Bournemouth** ranks among the best in the first five gameweeks.

But there is also bad news:

- They conceded 1.25 xG per game on average last season

- Ibrahima Konaté moved to Real Madrid, so the starting back four is likely to be Kerkez – van Dijk – Jacquet – Frimpong, with no pure ball-winning number six in front of them. That right side could be problematic, as this will be Jacquet's first Premier League season, and Frimpong isn't really a full-back
- They need to adapt to a new tactical approach, and it might take some time to click

Clean sheet points are marginal, but... points are points.

Verdict

Szoboszlai is priced at £7.0m, which is a pretty substantial investment.

You can get all of **Ismaila Sarr**, **Elliot Anderson**, **Dango Ouattara**, **Rayan**, **Estevao**, or **Kiernan Dewsbury-Hall** for £0.5m less. And both **Morgan Rogers** and **Florian Wirtz** cost just £0.5m more.

The argument for including him in the Gameweek 1 draft is that you can hold him through fixture swings without using transfers, which is a fair point and something you can utilise.

💡 **If your approach is to start the season as safely as possible, he's exactly the type of pick to go for:** a Premier League-proven asset with secure xMins who will be constantly involved and has huge ownership. You start the season safely, constantly monitor what's happening, and if it doesn't work out, there's always an easy one-transfer exit route.

You can counter this by saying that he offers very little goal threat, he'll likely play most of the time in a deeper role, there are cheaper mids who combine DEFCONs and some final product, or that you're not confident in Liverpool's team given the fair amount of uncertainty that comes with a new manager and a lack of squad depth. All those are valid arguments.

Overall, I'd say he's a nice pick for the current FPL meta, and there are many good arguments for including him, but I wouldn't call him a must-have. I can imagine several scenarios where he becomes an underwhelming pick. At the same time, I can imagine the exact opposite too.

For many seasoned managers, he's one of the toughest decisions when building a GW1 team. Hopefully, the rest of the pre-season offers enough signal to make it a bit easier.

That's all for today. See you very soon!

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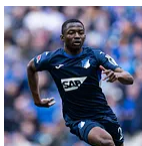
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